

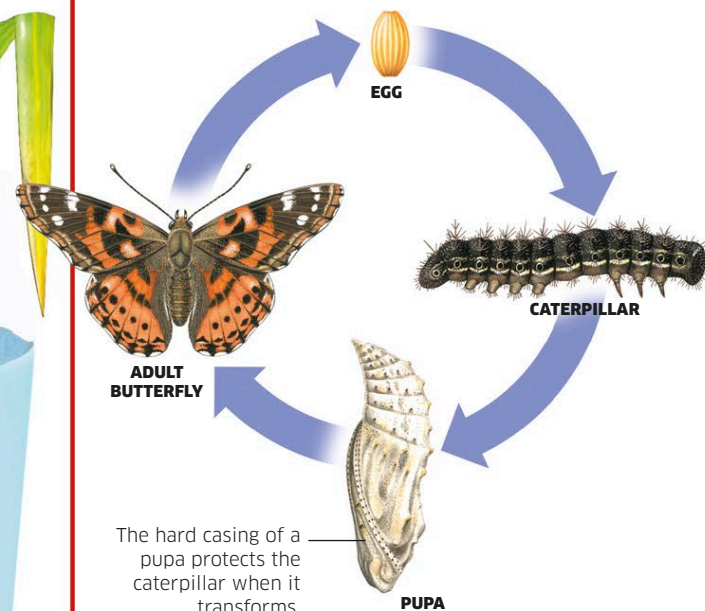
5 Dragonfly emerges

Just before its final molt, a nymph climbs up a plant out of the water. This time a dragonfly emerges from its skin.

It can take three hours for the insect's wings to harden so it can fly.

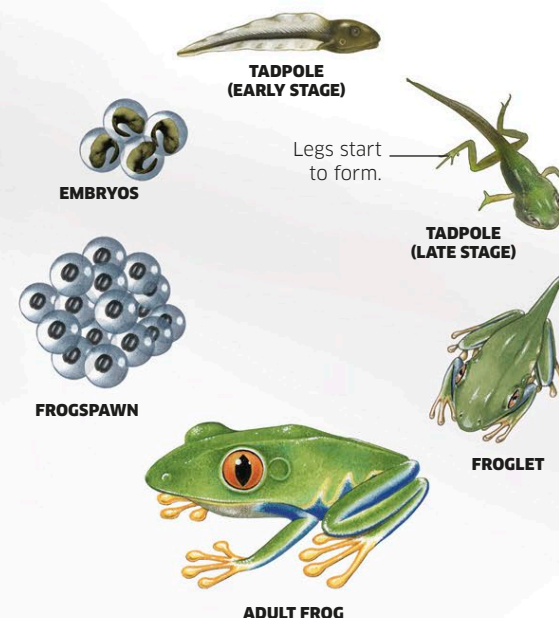
Complete metamorphosis

Along with many other insects, a butterfly undergoes a different kind of metamorphosis to a dragonfly. Its larva is a caterpillar, a leaf-eating creature that has no resemblance to the adult form at all. It changes into a flying butterfly in a single transformation event. This process is different to incomplete metamorphosis, where the multiple larval forms are smaller versions of the adult.



Amphibian life cycle

Amphibians grow more gradually than insects because they do not need to molt. Tiny wiggling tadpoles—with gills for breathing underwater—hatch from frogspawn and then take weeks or months to get bigger and turn into air-breathing frogs. During this time, they steadily grow their legs and their tails get absorbed back into their bodies.



Large nymph

The nymph passes through several more molts, growing each time. All insects must regularly molt their outer skin because this strong casing cannot expand as they grow.

Hunting tools

An Emperor Dragonfly nymph has a massive clawed lower "lip," which it can shoot out in just a fraction of a second to grab its prey. The nymphs can grow over 2 in (5 cm) long—large enough to grab large prey such as fish.

